

WEEK 2 · THE SOCIALLY CONSTRUCTED CHILD

CLASS 1

Socialization & Adultism

READING 1

“Children and Ritual in Bali” in *Traditional Balinese Culture* – Mead

READING 2

Adultism – Alderson

READING 3

Excerpts from *Theorizing Adultism* – Wall

(in-class only, not assigned)

Children and Ritual in Bali

MARGARET MEAD

IN BALI, children are called “small human beings,” and the conception of the nature and place of the child is different from that of the West. The whole of life is seen as a circular stage on which human beings, born small, as they grow taller, heavier, and more skilled, play predetermined roles, unchanging in their main outlines, endlessly various and subject to improvisation in detail.

The world of the dead is one part of the circle, from which human souls return, born again into the same family every fourth generation, to stay too briefly—dying before they have shared rice—or for a long time, or even for too long, for it is inappropriate for great-grandparents to be alive at the same time as their great-grandchildren. Such lingerers have to pay a penny to their great-grandchildren, chance-met on the street. The newborn child and the aged great-grandparent are both too close to the other world for easy entrance into the temple. The baby cannot enter until after a special feast at three and a half or seven months, and the very aged enter through a special side gate.

The newborn are treated as celestial creatures entering a more

Originally published in Margaret Mead and Martha Wolfenstein, eds., *Childhood in Contemporary Cultures* (Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 1955), pp. 40–51.

Author’s note: “Based on field work done in Bali, in 1936–39, by Gregory Bateson, Colin McPhee, Katharine Mershon, and myself. Bali is now part of modern Indonesia, and many parts of this description would no longer hold. I am using a historical present for the description of old, that is, pre-World War II, Bali.” Cf. Margaret Mead, “Researches in Bali, 1936–1939; on the Concept of Plot in Culture,” *Transactions of the New York Academy of Sciences*, Ser. II, Vol. II, No. 1 (November, 1939), pp. 1–4.

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humdrum existence and, at the moment of birth, are addressed with high-sounding honorific phrases reserved for gods, the souls of ancestors, princes, and people of a higher caste. Human beings do not increase in stature and importance, as is so often the case in societies where men have only one life to live; rather, they round a half-circle in which middle age, being farthest from the other world, is the most secular. There is little acceptance of any task being difficult or inappropriate for a child, except that an infant at birth is, of course, expected to do nothing for itself. Words are put into the mouth of the infant, spoken on its behalf by an adult; the hands of the seven-month-old baby are cupped to receive holy water, folded in prayer, opened to waft the incense offered to it as a god, and when the ceremony is over the child sits, dreamily repeating the gestures which its hands have momentarily experienced.¹

The Balinese may comment with amusement but without surprise if the leading metallophone player in a noted orchestra is so small that he has to have a stool in order to reach the keys; the same mild amusement may be expressed if someone takes up a different art after his hands have a tremor of age to confuse their precision. But in a continuum within which the distinction between the most gifted and the least gifted is muted by the fact that everyone participates, the distinction between child and adult—as performer, as actor, as musician—is lost except in those cases where the distinction is ritual, as where a special dance form requires a little girl who has not reached puberty.

This treatment of human history as an unending series of rebirths is matched in the treatment of the calendar. The Balinese have a whole series of weeks, of three, four, five, six, up to ten days, which turn on each other, like wheels of different sizes, and there are important occasions when two or three weeks recurrently coincide. These have special names and may be an occasion for festival—like Galungan, a New Year's feast associated with the souls of the dead, and a post-festival season of special theatricals. But, although there is a way of noting the year in a continuous irreversible sequence, it is seldom used. A man who has labored long to recopy a sacred text on pages of *lontar* palm will simply note, when his task of intricate elaboration of a beautiful archaic script is over, that this was finished on the such-and-such, a recurrent combination of days—as we might say, on Friday the thirteenth of September. The principal calendrical unit,

¹See *Karba's First Years* (film); Gregory Bateson and Margaret Mead, *Balinese Character: A Photographic Analysis* (New York, New York Academy of Sciences, 1942), Pl. 100, Figs. 1 and 2.

the ceremonial year, is two hundred and ten days long. The lunar calendar simply marks the pattern of planting and harvest.

Children, then, are smaller and more fragile than adults, as well as closer to the other world. Their essential personality characteristics—gaiety or seriousness, gentleness or harshness—are recognized early, and those around each child combine to set its formal character in an expected mold. The baby of six months with silver bracelets welded on its tiny wrists, waves and bangs its arms; if someone is hurt in the process, there comes the exclamation, “Isamā is harsh.” It takes only a few such acts to stereotype the judgment which will be echoed and re-echoed through its life, setting and defining its ways, but quite forgotten after death as other events—day of birth, experience in other incarnations—combine to give new personality. So, while the people take ritual pains over a corpse—that the individual may be born again fleeter of foot or more beautiful of face—they cannot describe the character or the looks of someone who died two years ago. Personality characteristics are accidents, held gently constant through any given incarnation, that dissolve at death. But the baby who is identified as “gay and mischievous” has a way of life plotted out for it, which again is independent of age. Old men who have been “gay” all their lives still know who sleeps with whom in the fields at night in the brief, wordless first encounters which for the Balinese represent the height of passion; and men and women labeled “serious” may bear many children, but people will comment instead on their industriousness in the rice fields or their faithfulness at the temple.

The child is made conscious of its sex very early. People pat the little girl’s vulva, repeating an adjective for feminine beauty, and applaud the little boy’s phallus with the word for “handsome male.” The child is fitted into words appropriate to its caste, gestures appropriate to each ceremony, and, before the child can walk, it is taught to dance with its hands. Before he can stand, the little boy, who has sat on his father’s knees while his father played the *gamelan*, begins to play himself. Peeking over a house wall, one may see diminutive girls of three, sitting all alone, practicing hand gestures. The child learns to walk around a single walking rail,² learning that it is safe as long as it holds to this central support, in danger of falling when it loosens its hold and strays out into the unknown. When it learns to walk, its

²See Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, Pl. 17, Figs. 1 and 2 (in this volume Plate IV); Margaret Mead and Frances Cooke Macgregor, *Growth and Culture: A Photographic Study of Balinese Childhood* (New York, Putnam, 1951), Pl. XXVI, Fig. 7, and Pl. LII, Fig. 3.

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ventures away from support and parents are controlled by the mother or child nurse mimicking terror and calling it back with threats that are random in content—“Tiger!” “Policeman!” “Snake!” “Feces!”—but constant in theatrical affect, until the child learns that undefined outer space may at any moment be filled with unknown terrors.³

In the village, in familiar territory, the child learns the directions—*kajă*, the center of the island, where the high mountain of the gods stands; *kělod*, toward the sea, the point of least sanctity; and *kangin*, to the right, *kauh*, to the left, when one faces *kajă*. Every act is likely to be expressed in these terms as babies are bidden to come a little *kajă* or to brush a speck off the *kělod* side of their face, and little boys of different caste play together happily but learn that the boy of higher caste must get into bed first or sit on the *kajă* side of the food tray.

Children learn the vertical hierarchies of life—that the head, even of a casteless peasant child, is something sacred, that a flower which has fallen to the ground from an offering carried on the head may not be replaced in the offering, that those of highest caste or sanctity must be given the highest seats. As they learn to speak, they learn that the words addressed to them by their elders and superiors are never the words in which they may answer, although sometimes the lesson is imperfectly learned, and a low-caste boy will marvel at the fact that “they say Brahmană parents are very polite to their children, that they say *tiang* to them,” not knowing that the children must reply with an exaggeratedly more polite term, *titiang*, in which the pronoun “I” is made more self-deprecating by a stylized stutter.

From birth until long after they can walk, children live most of their waking hours in human arms, carried in a sling or on the hip, even sleeping suspended about the neck of an adult or a child nurse.⁴ They learn a plastic adaptation, to take cognizance of the other’s movement in limp relaxation, neither resisting nor wholly following the pounding of the rice or the game the child nurse is playing. When there is teaching to be done, the teacher uses this flaccid adaptivity and, holding the hands and body of the learner with vigorous, precise intent, twists and turns them into place or pattern.⁵ Verbal directions are meager; children learn from the feel of other people’s bodies and from watching, although this watching itself has a kinesthetic quality.

³See *Karba’s First Years* (film); Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, pp. 30–32 and Pl. 46.

⁴See Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, Pl. 79; Mead and Macgregor, *Growth and Culture*, Pl. XVII.

⁵See *Karba’s First Years* (film); Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, Pl. 16.

An artist who attempts to draw a group of men will draw himself over and over again, feeling the image.

The children are everywhere. Very little babies cannot enter the temple, but the toddler is present in the midst of the most solemn ceremonial, attached to parent or grandparent, watching the blessing of the trance dancer, the throw of coins of the diviner, the killing of the fowl as exorcism. Women attending a theatrical performance carry their babies in their arms, and the front row of every performance is given over to the very small children, who watch and doze and are hastily rescued when the play threatens to break the bounds of the audience square and to involve the crowd in the plot. At the shadow play the children sit in front, and the puppet master increases the number of battles in the plot in proportion to the number of children. As the women kneel in the temple, placing the petals of a flower between their praying fingers, a flower is placed in the hands of the child who is with them. For the temple feast, small children, who at other times may run about stark naked, will appear elaborately dressed, boys in headdress and kris.

They look like dolls, and they are treated like playthings, playthings which are more exciting than fighting cocks—over which the men spend many fascinated hours—or the kites and crickets which amuse little boys. Everyone joins in the mild titillating teasing of little babies, flipping their fingers, their toes, their genitals, threatening them, playfully disregarding the sanctity of their heads, and, when the children respond by heightened excitement and mounting tension, the teaser turns away, breaks the thread of interplay, allows no climax.⁶ Children learn not to respond, to resist provocation, to skirt the group of elders who would touch or snatch, to refuse the gambit when their mothers borrow babies to make them jealous. They develop an unresponsiveness to the provocative intent of others at the same time that they remain plastic to music and pattern. It is a childhood training which, if followed here, would seem dangerously certain to bring out schizoid trends in the growing child's character.

But there is one great difference between Bali and the changing Western world as we know it. In the Western world children are traumatized in childhood in ways which are new and strange, for which no ritual healing, no artistic form, exists in the culture. Those who are very gifted may become prophets, or artists, or revolutionaries, using their hurt, their made deviancy, or their innate deviancy

⁶See *Karba's First Years* (film); Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, p. 32 and Pls. 47–49.

exaggerated by adult treatment as the basis for a new religion or a new art form. Those who are not so gifted or who are less fortunate in finding a medium for their gifts go mad or dwindle away, using little even of what they have. We are beginning to recognize how damaging a trauma can be—administered by a parent who is ignorant of the world the child lives in and lived out by the child in a still different world later. The present emphasis in America is on the application of psychiatric techniques—in childhood itself—to undo the damage, take out the false stitches, relearn the abandoned stance. Our conception of life is a sequential, changing, and climactic one. So a trauma in childhood is seen as producing mental damage or intolerable yearning, which must then be solved in later life—and solved alone by the traumatized individuals.⁷

Old Bali is a striking example of a quite different solution, in which the child each day meets rituals accurately matched to the intensities and the insatiabilities which are being developed by the interplay between itself and others. Little children are not permitted to quarrel, they are not allowed to struggle over toys, or to pull and claw at each other—there are always elders there to separate them, gently, impersonally, and inexorably, and so completely that, in over two years of living in Balinese villages, I never saw two children or adolescents fight. When conflict arises, the elder child is continually told to give in to the younger; the younger, responding to the invitation of the older, is jealous of every favor and demanding of anything the elder has.

But day after day, as the child is prevented from fighting, he sees magnificent battles on the stage, and the children are part of the crowd that streams down to the river bank to duck some character in the play. He sees the elder brother—who must always be deferred to in real life—insulted, tricked, defeated, in the theater. When his mother teases him in the eerie, disassociated manner of a witch, the child can also watch the witch in the play—the masked witch wearing the accentuated symbols of both sexes, with long protruding tongue, pendulous breasts, covered with repulsive hair—watch her recurrent battle with the dragon, who in his warmer and puppy-like behavior resembles his father. He can see the followers of the dragon attack the witch and fall down in a trance, as if killed, only to be brought back to life again by the magic healing power of the dragon.⁸ These

⁷See Mead, “The Arts in Bali,” in this volume, p. 331.

⁸See *Trance and Dance in Bali* (film); Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, pp. 34–35 and Pls. 55–58.

followers of the dragon, like the younger brother, go further than he will ever dare to go in showing hostility to his mother, in open resentment of her laughter. He sees his possible destructive wish lived out before his eyes, but in the end no one is slain, no one is destroyed, no one is hurt. The trancers, who have fallen into convulsions when they attack the witch, are revived by holy water and prayers, the play ends, the masks are taken off, the actors lay aside their golden garments for stained workday clothes; the young men who lay twitching in convulsions half an hour ago go off singing gaily for a bath. Over and over again, as babies in their mothers' arms, as toddlers being lifted out of the path of a pair of dancing warriors, as members of the solemn row of children who line the audience square, they see it happen—the play begins, mounts to intensity, ends in ritual safety. And in the villages, when theatrical troupes under the protection of the dragon mask, patron of the theater and enemy of death, parade about a village in which they have just arrived, people buy a little of the dragon's hair as bracelets for their children to protect them from evil dreams.⁹

In this absence of change, the experience of the parent is repeated in that of the child, and the child, a full participant in ritual and art, is presented with the last elaborations almost with its first breath. The people themselves treat time as a circular process rather than a progressive one, with the future ever behind one, unrolling beneath one's feet, an already exposed but undeveloped film. Here we find a perfect expression of the historical nature of culture, in which any separation between cause and effect, any attempt to turn either childhood experience or adult ritual into the cause, one of the other, is seen to be a hopeless endeavor. The two recur together, at every stage; the teased baby of the witchlike human mother watches the witch on the stage, and the teasing mother, even as she teases her baby, also sees the witch, attacked, apparently destroying, but in the end doing no harm. The effect on child and mother must both be reckoned in a round of simultaneous events, repeating and repeating until the child in arms again becomes a parent.

And yet, in spite of their conception of life as a circle, we may, if we wish, break the circle—as they are unwilling to do—and, for purposes of a type of scientific analysis born of our Western conceptions of time, space, and causality, ask the question: What happens as babies born to Balinese parents, equipped at birth with the same potentialities

⁹See Margaret Mead, "The Strolling Players in the Mountains of Bali," in this volume, p. 137.

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as other human babies, learn to be Balinese? How do they make the ritual of Balinese life part of themselves and so become as able to dance the intricate dances, carve or play or weave or go into trance, as did their parents or their grandparents? How do they learn to be Balinese and so perpetuate Balinese culture? This is no question which treats Balinese culture as a mere projection from childhood experience. The themes enacted in the Balinese theater have a long history.¹⁰ On the shadow-play screen there appear the heroes and heroines of the *Ramayana*, the great Indian epic. The witch *rangdā* is also the Javanese Chalonarang, and she is also Durgā, the destroyer. The dragon is found around the world—in Japan, in the streets of New York for Chinese New Year, where he blesses the local merchants whose restaurants may contain a juke box or a cigarette-vending machine. It is only in the particular details of the plots that one can find the distinctive mark of Balinese culture—in the refusal to let the witch die, in the permission to show a violence on the stage which is not permitted in real life, and in the way in which artist, actor, and priest participate in everyday life.

But children in Bali, like human children everywhere, are born helpless, dependent, and cultureless and must be bathed and fed and protected, taught to balance and to walk, to touch and to refrain from touching, to relate themselves to other people, to talk, to work, to become sure members of their own sex, and finally to marry and produce and rear children. We cannot find that which is distinctively Balinese in the mere presence of the witch and the dragon, who recur in many forms throughout the world. It is necessary to look at fine details of difference. For example, the Balinese witch has got hold of a dragon's fiery tongue—and the Balinese dragon has no tongue at all. This can be seen as a part of the way in which the witch combines all the gross overaccentuated aspects of secondary sex characters. In the Balinese ideal physical type, both men and women are slender; male breasts are more pronounced than among us; women's breasts are high and small; hips of both sexes are closer in dimensions. Men are almost beardless, and the muscles of their arms are not developed. The witch's hairy legs and long pendulous breasts accentuate the frightening aspects of highly developed sex differences, and we find, counterpointing her, protecting the people from the illness and death she brings, and presiding with her over the theater, the dragon, a mythical creature, wearing lovely fluffy, feather-like "hair" or crow

¹⁰See Jane Belo, *Bali: Rangda and Barong* (New York, J. J. Augustin, 1949).

feathers sent especially by the gods. Only as the Balinese witch is contrasted with her historical predecessors and as the Balinese dragon is seen in a world perspective of other dragons, is it possible to say what is distinctively Balinese. In the same way, by placing Balinese childhood experience in a context of our knowledge of child development, we can see in what particular ways Balinese children, while repeating universal human experiences, also have special ones.

The Balinese infant has preserved a kind of neonatal flexibility, which in the children who have been studied in Western culture tends to disappear very early, so that both the way a baby relaxes in its mother's arms and the way the mother holds it are sharply contrasting to our patterns.¹¹ The disallowance of infancy, as adults speak in behalf of the child or press its compliant learning hands into ritual gestures, is again distinctive; and the way in which the child is constantly discouraged from walking, taught to use its right hand rather than the left, which is exposed by the carrying posture, left free to drink from its mother's breast when it chooses, as it is carried high above her high breast, but fed in a helpless prone position as a mound of prechewed food is piled on its mouth—all these details go to build the kind of Balinese personality which will be receptive to rituals danced and acted by others who have been treated in the same way. The constant provocative teasing and threatening which never reaches any but a theatrical climax, the denial of all violence and expressed hostility toward siblings, the serial experience of being the pampered baby, the displaced knee baby, and the child nurse, who, as guardian of the baby, stays to see the usurper dethroned in turn, all these form a background for the plots of ritual and theater to which the child is exposed.¹²

But there is something more here than the correspondence between childhood experience and dramatic plot, something different from the sort of cultural situation discussed by Róheim when a terrifying infantile experience—of a male child sleeping beneath the mother—is abreacted by initiation rites in adolescence.¹³ In Bali the absence of sequence even in the life-span of the individual and the absence of discontinuity between ritual role and everyday role seem crucial. The artist, the dancer, the priest, is also a husbandman who tills his rice

¹¹ See Mead and Macgregor, *Growth and Culture*, Pls. XXXIX–XLI.

¹² See Margaret Mead, "Age Patterning in Personality Development," *American Journal of Orthopsychiatry*, XVII, No. 2 (1947), 231–40.

¹³ Geza Róheim, *The Riddle of the Sphinx* (London, Hogarth Press and Institute of Psychoanalysis, 1934).

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fields. Occasionally an artist becomes so famous that he lets his fingernails grow as he does no other work, and, say the Balinese, he begins to grow fat and careless and lazy, and his artistic skills decrease. The priest may stand robed in white during a ceremony, officiating at the long ritual of inviting the gods down to earth, dressing them, feeding them, bathing them, presenting them with dance and theater, and then sending them back again for another two hundred and ten days in heaven.¹⁴ But the day after the ceremony he is a simple citizen of the village, only owing the land which he cultivates to his work on feast days as guardian of the temple.

Nor is there any gap between professional and amateur. There are virtually no amateurs in Bali, no folk dancing in which people do traditional things without responsibility to an artistic canon.¹⁵ There are enormous differences in skill and grace and beauty of performance, but prince and peasant, very gifted and slightly gifted, all do what they do seriously and become, in turn, critical spectators, laughing with untender laughter at the technical failures of others. Between the audience that gathers to watch the play and the players there is always the bond of professional interest, as the audience criticizes the way the actor or actress who plays the princess postures or sings, rather than identifying with her fate—however lost she may be in some dense theatrical forest.

Nor is there any gap between rehearsal and performance. From the moment an orchestra begins to practice an old piece of music, there is a ring of spectators, aspiring players, substitute players, small boys, and old men, all equally engrossed in the ever fresh creation of a new way of playing an old piece of music.¹⁶ Where in Java the shadow-play screen divided men from women, the women seeing only the faint shadow on the screen, the men the brightly painted figures, in Bali people can sit on either side, in front to watch the finished play, behind—and this is where little boys prefer to sit—to watch the individual designs on the figures and the deft hands of the puppet master. When a village club decides to learn a new play—a play in which the main serious parts are traditional and the parts of clowns, servants, and incidental characters are all improvised, never set, even in consecutive performances—half the village attends the rehearsals, enjoys the discussions of costume, the sharp words of the visiting virtuoso come to

¹⁴See Jane Belo, *Bali: Temple Festival* (Locust Valley, N.Y., J. J. Augustin, 1953).

¹⁵See Margaret Mead, "Community Drama, Bali and America," in this volume, p. 341; Colin McPhee, "Dance in Bali," in this volume, p. 290.

¹⁶See Colin McPhee, *A House in Bali* (New York, John Day, 1946).

teach a dance step, the discovery of some new talent among the actors. In the rectangular piece of ground which becomes a four-sided stage as the audience gathers around it, isolated pairs of curtains borrowed from a theater with a quite different style of handling surprise may be set up near each end. The actors, their crowns a little askew, sit in almost full view dozing behind these curtains or among the audience, and then, as they make their appearance, part the curtain for a prolonged stylized “entrance,” from which they later return to their full visibility offstage.¹⁷ People advance from the audience to pin up a dancer’s fallen scarf, and dramatic scenes of chase and conquest will be pursued into the midst of the audience.

Thus in Bali the ritual world of art and theater and temple is not a world of fantasy, an endless recurrent daydream, or a new set of daydreams woven from the desperations of the gifted of each generation. It is rather a real world of skill and application—a world in which members of a dance club scheme to get money for the gold of a new headdress or to buy new instruments for the orchestra; where long hours are spent in the basic work of learning to dance; where disciplined hands and wrists and eyes that click to one side in perfect time to the music, are all the result of continuous, although relaxed, rather dreamy, work. And the temple feasts, where many of these activities combine to make a great spectacle, are called appropriately “the work of the gods.”

Children have not only the precocious postural participation in prayer and offering, dance and music, but also a whole series of parallel participations. A little boy will be given bamboo clappers with which to imitate the clapping of the dragon’s tongueless jaws and, covered by his mother’s cloth shawl—the same shawl with which the witch will dance in the play and which she will carry in her arms as if it were a baby—goes about clapping in imitation of the dragon. In the nonceremonial seasons, when life is a little less crowded, secular dance clubs go about with a tinkly orchestra, which has a hurdy-gurdy quality, and a little girl dancer, who dances with the young men of the village and, in between, dances as the witch, combining the beautiful ballet of the witch’s disciples with being the witch herself and placing her foot firmly on the neck of a doll, enacting her role of bringing death.¹⁸

Children stay in a deep resistant sleep during a childbirth in their

¹⁷See Margaret Mead, “The Strolling Players in the Mountains of Bali,” in this volume, p. 137.

¹⁸See Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, Pls. 60–62.

houses, a sleep from which it is necessary to shake them awake, lest they see the witches which may come to kill the child. But the same children participate with delight in the play in which the witch child, after stealing a doll, born of a man and dressed as a woman, is chased up a tree or into a nearby stream. Children make puppets of banana leaf and parody the puppet master, especially the puppet master who performs with puppets in the daytime, whose screen has shrunk to a single line of thread. They draw in the sand with twigs while master artists work at little shallow wooden tables. And children may form clubs of their own, make their own dragon and witch, and progress about the village, collecting pennies for further finery for the masks.¹⁹

If one follows these activities carefully, notes the expressions on the children's faces at different kinds of ceremonies, follows the same child on different occasions, and watches the play in which the children think they are reproducing the full theatricals, one begins to get clues to the dynamic mechanisms by which the children, born human like all other human children, become such very different people from other people—as Balinese. The mother who teases her child—who borrows a baby to provoke its jealousy, although preventing any expression of jealousy of a real sibling; who borrows a baby to set on its head, although at the same time protecting its head from real insult—has learned that all this is a safe game. When she watches the witch dance and watches the men and women who have gone into trance and are slow in coming out, she watches with the same relaxed enjoyment or ready criticism for some ritual or technical defect with which she watches the trance dance in which children dance as goddesses. But the child, teased into a violent temper, screaming and clawing to get the borrowed baby away from his mother's breast, has not yet learned that all this is safe. In his intensity and grief, in his fervent acceptance of his mother's theatrical amends for a real hurt, he still shows a capacity for hurt which will not be manifest later. Even as he withdraws from the recurrently disappointing sequences which have no climax, he learns to trust the arts, and he learns to avoid hurting responsiveness to human stimulation.²⁰

The faces of the children who watch the trance dance in which little girls replace dancing wooden puppets—and child dancers are indulged by their parents and wilful in their demands—are as relaxed as their parents' faces. But during the witch dance the children's

¹⁹ See Colin McPhee, *A Club of Small Men* (New York, John Day, 1947).

²⁰ See Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*.

faces are strained and anxious.²¹ When the witch dances or when some woman worshiper in the temple is possessed by the witch, the fingers are flexed backward in a gesture of fear, spoken of as *kapar*—the gesture made by a baby falling or a man falling from a tree—for the witch is both frightening and afraid, the picture of Fear itself.²² But when children play the witch, especially when they play her without benefit of costume or music or any of the elements which accompany the finished ritual, their hands are bent like claws, and they threaten an attack in witchlike gestures which can be found in many parts of the world. When the young men, who, as followers of the dragon, fall down before the witch's magic, thrust their daggers against their breasts, they thrust them in response to an intolerable itching feeling in their breasts—a possible reciprocal to the mother's breast during the period when they were so teased, provoked, and given only theatrical climaxes.

When Balinese children are frightened of strangers or strange situations, their elders shout at them, "Don't show fear!" and they learn not to run but to stand stock still, often with their hands pressed over their eyes.²³ In situations of danger or uncertainty—during childbirth in a tiny one-room house, after an accident for which one may be blamed—children and older people also fall into a deep sleep from which it is hard to rouse them.

The Balinese move easily in a group. A whole village may make a pilgrimage of two or three days to make offerings at the seaside or in the high mountains. A troupe of Balinese went to the Paris Exposition in 1931, and a troupe visited New York in 1952. But one Balinese, isolated from those he knows and taken to a strange place, wilts and sickens; people say it is because he is *paling*—disoriented—the word used for trance, insanity, for being drunk, confused, or lost. And the Balinese are mortally afraid of drunkenness, where the clues to the directions, the calendar, the caste system, the framework of life—which gives safety as the walking rail gave it to the little child who learned how dangerous it was to venture away from it—are lost or blurred.

Following the children as they grow up reveals that, even within the simultaneity of ritual satisfaction and individual fear, the capacity to enjoy such rituals, to dance the lovely dances and fill the air with

²¹ See *Trance and Dance in Bali* (film).

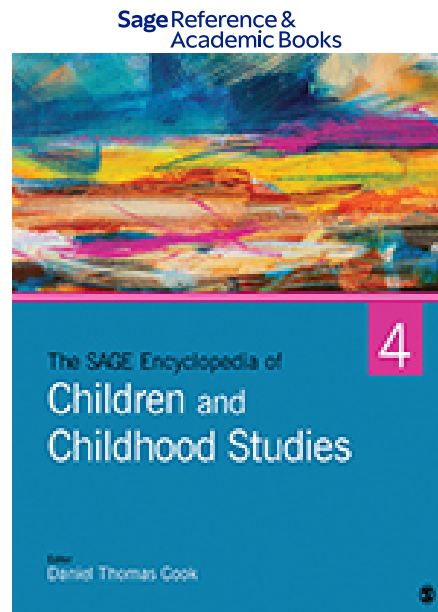
²² See *Trance and Dance in Bali* (film); Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, Pl. 62.

²³ See Bateson and Mead, *Balinese Character*, Pl. 67.

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music, has been—in the case of the Balinese—developed at certain costs. The culture contains—or did contain until the recent upheavals about which we know little—ritual solutions for the instabilities it created, and the people, on their little island, were safe. But it was the safety of a tightrope dancer, beautiful and precarious.



Sage Reference

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Adultism

As sexism is to women, adultism is to children and young people. Some confusions about the term and some problems that adultism can amplify are considered in this entry. From the 1960s onwards, the campaign for women's rights was advanced by two useful words. First, *sexism* succinctly identified the root of the problem of discrimination against women. It transferred the blame for women's inferior status and their seeming lesser ability and lower intelligence when compared with men away from women themselves and onto powerful social structures of prejudice. Gradually these sexist structures are being identified and dismantled, and women have growing opportunities to show that they can be at least equal to men.

The second useful word, *feminism*, turned what might have been a weak negative term about disadvantaged inferior women into the name for a powerful positive movement. Similar words linked to former weakness and shame have been transformed into slogans of strength and triumph, such as Black Pride and Gay Pride to fight racism and homophobia. Children have no such clear language to advance their status. *Adultism* and *childism* are seldom-used terms and, confusingly, childism sometimes denotes respect for children, like feminism, but sometimes denigrates them, like sexism. Similarly, adultism can mean positive respect for adults, or criticism of overbearing adults besides disrespect for children.

The international power that adultism denotes of adults' coercive control over children endures in practice partly because the theory and language needed to challenge it remain undeveloped and confused. Sexism and racism are now so well recognised that there are laws against them. Yet there are no laws against the routine denigrating of children, and even *childish* is assumed to be an insulting word. Perhaps because all the discriminated-against adult minority groups are now more protected, denigrating of children has increased; disadvantaged adults feel less shared solidarity with children than formerly, and they risk seeming childish themselves if they side with children. So childhood is still further isolated from adulthood than when, for example, children and women used to be scorned equally.

Adultism has been the diagnosis for a supposed mental disease in promiscuous adolescents who commit adult crimes such as prostitution. This links to the way adult and adultism frequently denote libertarian and sexual concerns, from which children are expected to be excluded. This firm exclusion of children lends a useful moral veneer to what could seem to be immoral or amoral libertarianism. Protecting children, who are seen as too young to make choices or to guard themselves from dangers, can seem to be the caring, responsible moral side of the libertarian coin that would otherwise be purely selfish and lawless.

Just as adults can exist only when there are children (otherwise everyone would simply be 'people'), adultism

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depends on the inferior age group of children to validate claims that adults are superior and reliable and that it is therefore normal, natural, and moral that adults should control supposedly volatile irresponsible children. So adultism usually denotes prejudice against children and excessive respect for adults.

Can adults be excessively respected? Do adults not show the highest levels of reason, maturity, wisdom, and altruism that human beings can achieve? Yes, some adults do, but many do not, whereas many children and young people are reasonable, wise, and kind. However, although sexism and racism are clearly misguided and unjustly deny adults' equal rights, children do not fully share this equality. And many children benefit from adults' authority and responsibility provided the adults are respectful and benign.

Adultism and developmentalism are problems when they falsely correlate virtue and ability with age. Adultism overestimates adults. It splits off their negative and failing qualities, and projects these onto children while assuming that all virtues such as being wise, kind, and reliable exist only in adults, and therefore adult control must not be questioned. Adultism works in self-fulfilling prophecies by setting unjustly high barriers and low expectations for children's involvement in activities and relationships, increasing children's likely failures and attributing these to their incompetence and their need to be subordinate.

Jack Flasher identified adultism as the abuse of power over children through excessive nurturing, possessiveness, and restrictions by parents, teachers, psychotherapists, the clergy, police, judges, and juries. Erica Burman criticised imperial adultism, which treats childhood as a domain to be colonised and civilised and which shapes public understanding and policies that demean children through adult-centred paternalistic research and services. Adam Fletcher analysed institutional adultism at three levels: attitudinal, cultural, and structural.

Donovon Ceaser found that adultism is so endemic that it even pervades programmes deliberately concerned with social justice that aim to increase equality. Adultism worked in one such programme, unnoticed by the adults, although not by the young people, intersecting with prejudices of race, sex, and class until Ceaser drew the organisers' attention to these hidden influences.

Barry Checkoway contended that young people internalise adultism, which causes them to question their own legitimacy and ability, their trust in themselves, and their trust in their peers, leading to their overdependence on adults' approval. Violent forms of physical, sexual, verbal, and routine adultism set up complex chains of reactions of distress, anxiety, and anger for young people. Adultism limits their abilities to engage in peaceful, cooperative, mutually respectful, and democratic activities.

Adultism is sometimes said to 'socially construct' children, but as real human beings, children cannot be constructed like mindless passive Lego models. However, their beliefs, behaviours, and relationships as well as

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their sense of identity and how others regard and treat them can all be powerfully influenced by adultism. In many ways, adultism can damage not only young people but whole present and future societies. As with sexism, progress begins with naming and openly challenging the great problems of adultism.

See also [Baby](#); [Social Construction of](#); [Child as Other/Stranger](#); [Childhood Studies](#); [Developmentality](#); [Infantilization](#)

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*Article*

Theorizing adultism: From adult domination to normative disempowerment

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Abstract

This article develops a critical theory of adultism that can help both childhood studies and the larger academy to make visible the normative marginalization of children as children. Going beyond existing critical theories concerning sexism, racism, colonialism, and the like, adultism is formulated as a theory of normative disempowerment. In this way, it can function intersectionally to uncover the distinctive role of dominating adult-child binary oppositions both in childhood and across societies generally. After unpacking the history of concepts of adultism, the article constructs a systemic theory of adultism across three dimensions of ontological human being, epistemological knowledge, and political power.

Keywords

Adultism, critical theory, empowerment, epistemology, ontology, power

Introduction

Scholars in childhood studies have developed a wide range of empirical and theoretical analyses of children's social marginalization. These include studies of children's racial inequality (Cox, 2015; Halliday, 2017; Phoenix, 2023), gender discrimination (Dyer, 2020; Hodgins, 2019; Rosen and Balagopalan, 2023), disabilities (Goodley et al., 2020; Runswick-Cole et al., 2023; Watson, 2012), and colonization (Balagopalan, 2019; Rollo, 2018; Tetteh, 2013; Twum-Danso Imoh, 2024). It is less common, however, to examine children's subordination in their status specifically as children (Daly et al., 2022; Wall, 2019a; Warming, 2024). There is a sense in which childhood studies automatically thematizes children's subordinated perspectives simply by studying children in their own

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right. But my argument here is that the field as a whole lacks systemic theoretical tools for the critical analysis of the social marginalization of children as such. As a result, childhood studies not only fails to fully grasp children's specific exclusion as children, but it also cannot mount broader critiques of this problem in academic research at large.

In the following, I develop just such a critical theory through a normative conceptualization of adultism. The term “adultism” has taken on a variety of meanings in both childhood studies and other types of scholarship for over a century. It stands in different kinds of relation to cognate terms like ageism, patriarchy, and infantilization. But it has yet to be clearly formulated in a normative sense, that is, as able to offer structural critiques of social and scholarly assumptions. A normative concept of adultism would focus, not just on occasional instances of adult domination or control, but on adult-child binary oppositions that justify wholesale systems of understanding and power. It would provide a critical lens similar to those found in concepts like sexism, racism, and decoloniality (Biswas, 2023; Wall, 2023). Just as diverse critical theories offer intersectional types of social critique, so also is it possible for adultism to function intersectionally from its own distinct perspective. Indeed, understanding problems like sexism and racism depend in part on understanding adultism, not only as an important dimension of oppression in its own right, but also insofar as suppressed groups find themselves frequently coded as childlike. What the concept of adultism contributes most importantly, I suggest, is a lens for examining how constructions of adulthood function as broadly disabling systems of social disempowerment.

The history of a concept

Adultism and similar terms have been in use in English-language scholarship since the early 20th century. The concept has found, however, a wide range of meanings over time. In the following brief analysis of these diverse senses of the term, one can find a gradual evolution from non-systemic and non-normative uses to what may be called increasingly more critical and structural possibilities. It is only with the advent of the field of childhood studies in the 1990s that more fully systemic senses of the term start to develop, but even here they have yet to be formulated in fully normative terms. An examination of this history of concepts of adultism helps to lay out exactly what remains yet to be theorized if the term is to take its place as a broadly critical lens on social life.

The earliest known appearance of the word adultism is in a popular book for parents by education writer DuBois (1903) titled *Fireside Child-Study: The Art of Being Fair and Kind*. Here the term is used to describe parents' and teachers' acts of domination over the children in their care. Inspired by John Dewey and the child study movement, DuBois argues that “the undue interposition by the adult of his adultism—his adult point of view—between himself and the child is the main, if not the only real, hindrance to the child's proper development” (35). This domination over children in the home and school represents a personal attitude on the part of certain adults of “absolute possession, unlimited right, and infallible judgment” and “shows itself in the lust for authority” (8). Adultism here refers to adult control over children in direct and immediate ways. (Another early use of the term is found in Courbon (1933) to refer to sexual and criminal

“precocious growth” among youth, but this very different concept is not to my knowledge taken up again).

DuBois’s notion of adultism is recovered and broadened in the 1970s and 1980s by the influential developmental psychologist [Flasher \(1978\)](#). Flasher looks beyond personal interactions to describe adultism as any adult’s “misuse of power” over children (p. 517). Adults already have more power than children in most ways, and adultism describes the ways this power can be abused. In Flasher’s view, the problem with adults’ misuse of power is that it discourages children’s “thought” and “autonomy” and therefore functions as a chief cause of children’s “dissocial behavior” (p. 517). A related point is made around the same time by the psychiatrists Chester Pierce and Gail Allen ([1975](#)), who argue that children are oppressed by the “microaggressions” imposed on them by adults via socialization mechanisms like television, so that “the child is expected to accommodate himself to the adult-aggressor” and thereby also learns “to be an oppressor” in their own future adult life (though they use the term “childism” and not adultism to name this problem) (p. 18). The feminist scholar Elise Boulding similarly argues that what she calls “ageism” takes place when adults “segregate” children by denying children’s (and the elderly’s) needs and rights to support, nurturance, and care (1979). Likewise, the educationalist John Holt describes “adultism” as any “adult intervention” that suppresses children’s full self-expression (1981, p. 222). These notions of adultism widen it into a critique, in part echoing feminist and civil rights insights of the time, of any misuse, whether personal or political, of adult power over children.

There is one further way that the concept of adultism develops prior to the emergence of new ideas in childhood studies. This further possible meaning, grounded primarily in developmental psychology, is first formulated by the activist and organizer John Bell. Bell argues that “adultism” arises from a broad social attitude of “disrespect of the young” ([Bell, 1995: 14](#)). Bell’s argument is that it is this generalized societal disrespect that underlies children’s mistreatment, such as by physical punishment, banning from public spaces, or lacking voices in families, schools, communities, and politics. Such a notion is also taken up by the renowned social work scholar Barry Checkoway as a way to explain why adults often fail to recognize or ally with youth activists. Arguing that “the essence of adultism is that young people are not respected,” Checkoway claims that “adultism refers to all of the behaviors and attitudes that flow from the assumption that adults are better than young people, and are entitled to act upon young people in many ways without their agreement” ([1996: 14](#)). A similar notion is described by the psychoanalyst Elisabeth Young-Bruehl to describe adults’ pervasive and damaging attitudes of “prejudice against children,” prejudices akin to racism, antisemitism, and homophobia that give rise to disrespect and violence (2012). Adultism from this perspective names a generalized social attitude that young people are not owed the same level of respect as adults simply because they are young.

Starting in the 1990s, adultism comes to be understood from a significantly different perspective in the then new field of childhood studies. Childhood studies turns the tables to examine adultism from the perspective not so much of adults as of children themselves. Adultism starts to evolve from a concept describing adult attitudes and behaviors, however broad, to one now describing children’s own experiences as children. This new

set of ideas grows out of the notion articulated by Alison James and Alan Prout that children must be seen as “active in the construction and determination of their own social lives,” and that “children’s social relationships and cultures are worthy of study in their own right, independent of the perspective and concerns of adults” (1990, p. 8). Adultism, and much else, is examined from the point of view of children themselves. It is remarkable, in fact, that a century of prior analyses of adultism should have been conducted more or less entirely from the perspective of adults, itself an attestation to adultism’s power. In short, in childhood studies the concept emerges of understanding children’s marginalization in children’s own terms.

From this new perspective, adultism comes to be defined initially as children’s experience of adult oppression. The feminist scholars Daisy Hernandez and Bushra Rehman, in their book *Colonize This!* (2002), compare children’s experiences of “adultism” to those of sexism and racism, inasmuch as adultism points to the ways that children encounter being “colonized” by “the institutional power adults have to oppress and silence young people” (p. 101). Children in this sense find themselves systemically barred from acting in the world and making their voices heard. Unlike in Young-Bruehl and others above, the comparison to sexism and racism is about the impact on children themselves, rather than the attitudes of adults. A similar childhood studies notion is developed by sociologists Lucien Lombardo and Karen A. Polonko, who argue that “similar to sexism, racism and classism, adultism refers to a system of structured inequality or oppression that permeates relationships between children and adults” (2010: 94). Adultism on this view manifests as a system of attitudes and practices built into age relations that limit and undermine children’s own senses of their opportunities for social influence.

A second formulation can be found in childhood studies around the notion of adultism as a social construct. Here, the emphasis is placed less on children’s silencing and more on children’s inequality. The most prominent examples can be found in sociologists Barry Thorne and Berry Mayall and their concepts of “age” and “generation.” Thorne models “the study of age” on “the study of gender, racial ethnicity, sexuality, [and] social class” and argues that age can be used as a lens for “examining multiple lines of difference and inequality” (2001, pp. 403–4). The perspective of age helps unpack children’s experiences of the social constructions that force their lives into a secondary status compared to adults’. In a similar way, Mayall draws on feminism to argue that “the underdog provides essential evidence of the working of the social order—the degree of ‘fit’ between assumptions and prescriptions of the ruling social order and people’s experiences and understandings” (2002, p. 2). What she calls a “generational” analysis enables scholars to “think from [children’s] lives towards sociological understanding” (2002, p. 1). Or, as Leena Alanen likewise puts it, “the notion of a generational structure or order refers to a complex set of social processes through which people become (are constructed as) ‘children’ while other people become (are constructed as) ‘adults’” (2001: 20–21). This notion of adultism lays bare the ways that constructions of childhood force children into an unequal status.

A third and slightly different formulation arising from childhood studies can be found in more recent uses of the term adultism to describe systems of social discrimination.

Adultist discrimination refers to social structures of anti-child bias. For example, postcolonial feminist scholar Mehmoona Moosa-Mitha uses the term adultism to explain how children experience themselves as “not-yet-citizens” or “second-class citizens” (2005: 371 and 374). Children encounter intergenerational discrimination because of underlying historical biases against them. Psychologists Jocelyn Gregoire and Christin Jungers similarly describe “adultism” as an issue that therapists need to address in child counseling because of the harm caused to children by “prejudice and accompanying systematic discrimination against young people” (2007: 65). And in a book titled *Facing Adultism* (2015), the political activist Adam Fletcher shows that adultism in the form of “discrimination against young people” is the chief obstacle facing children and youth in making meaningful impacts upon their social environments. Understood as a form of discrimination, adultism broadens the scope of analysis from children’s particular experiences of child-adult relations to children’s encounters with biased historical systems.

This brief history of the concept of adultism and its cognates yields two main conclusions so far. First, scholars and activists have learned over time to think of adultism as less about the actions and attitudes of adults and more about the experiences and struggles of children. This shift makes sense when one considers that sexism and racism are likewise better understood from the perspectives less of the oppressors than of those being oppressed, that is, in the marginalized group’s own experiences of silencing, disrespect, and domination. And second, adultism is not occasional but structural. That is, the term is more usefully employed to describe, not just particular experiences of being disrespected, important though these are to understand, but also underlying systems of relations and biases that construct the fundamentally second-class status of childhood itself. Adultism is again akin to other forms of marginalization in that, while it has many different particular manifestations, especially as inflected by intersectionality, these are empowered by societally shared and historically enforced social structures. Overall, then, adultism has come to be understood as a lens for understanding children’s experiences of systemic suppression.

Toward a new concept of adultism

The above advances in understanding adultism are significant and important. But they suffer from one major flaw that the remainder of this essay seeks to overcome. This flaw, in a nutshell, is that adultism is still understood chiefly in terms of other forms of marginalization. It is still primarily modeled on theoretical insights from feminism, racism, colonialism, and the like. The problem here is that, unlike in these other perspectives, adultism has yet to be theorized as a distinct critical perspective in its own right. That is, while it may share a great deal with experiences of sexism, racism, colonialism, ableism, and the like, it is likely at the same time to function somewhat differently. Indeed, any intersectional analysis of oppression depends on different angles of critique introducing their own specific language and ideas. Sexism does not operate on exactly the same logic as racism, nor racism in the same way as colonialism, nor colonialism exactly like ableism, and so on. What, though, is distinct about adultism? What are the dynamics

of its own particular experience? What, in other words, makes adultism particular to children?

To unpack what is distinct about adultism, the remainder of this paper formulates a child-specific conception of children's marginalization across three key dimensions: an ontology of human being, an epistemology of knowledge, and a politics of power. These dimensions together suggest that adultism exposes marginalization as an experience, not just for children but also in part for any marginalized group, of normative disempowerment. It shows that social domination relies on an interdependent dynamics in which the empowerment of some relies on the disempowerment of others. While such a logic could in principle pertain to any systemically suppressed group, it is in its particular expression in adultism that it makes its sharpest and clearest expression.

Adultism and the construction of being

First, in terms of ontology, or ideas about human being, adultism can be understood to construct childhood as that which lacks human being, not just socially or culturally, but by nature. Adultism involves the assumption that children are not only historically lesser beings but lesser in their very essence. Indeed, adultism establishes a child-adult binary that constructs "childhood" as a state of being that is somehow in important respects still a part of nature and therefore non-human. To the extent that a person or group is a "child," they embody a supposedly biological, neurological, pre-linguistic, or even spiritual realm of non-human human being. They do not yet possess what makes humanity distinct from all other forms of being. Put differently, adultism constructs childhood as a mode of existence that negates itself. It relegates childhood to a state of being that, paradoxically, must overcome its own childlikeness to achieve whatever is thought to separate humanity from nature.

It is this ontological construction that distinguishes adultism from other modes of social marginalization. Sexism may construct women as naturally lesser than men, but it does not associate women with non-humanity as such. Racism does not oppress minorities on the basis of their not yet having overcome their biological non-Whiteness. While colonialism is more similar to adultism in this regard, it nevertheless assumes that colonized peoples, if supposedly closer to nature, are not themselves representative of nature itself. In contrast, adultism proclaims that childhood lacks fully adult humanity by its very ontological being. It imagines childhood as still at least somewhat existing in a state of nature and so having as its purpose to negate and surpass itself in an eventual humanity. Not only is childhood defined in relation to adulthood – just as womanhood is defined in relation to manhood and Blackness in relation to Whiteness – but childhood *is* adulthood, just not yet. Childhood can only exist as a state of adulthood-to-be. The result is that adultism constructs childhood, not just as a lesser state of human being, but as a peculiarly, indeed paradoxically, *non-human* state of human being.

This association of childhood with nature creates a false binary opposition between childhood and adulthood. As the childhood studies philosopher Karin Murriss suggests, "[a]geist prejudices are directly related to the Nature/Culture binary, which ... positions child as an ontological, colonized 'other'" (2018: 16). Childhood functions under

adultism or ageism as a symbolic representation of humanity's domination over the natural world. Childlikeness comes to represent whatever is non-rational, uncivilized, or pre-cultural – that is, whatever humanity as such surpasses. In other words, as Rachel Rosen puts it, “childhood continues to be one of the last acceptable bastions of essentialism” (2018: 423). Other marginalized groups, however dehumanized, remain with the sphere of human possibility. But children stand for the absence of human possibility. An adultist logic demands that children can gain a measure of humanity only insofar as they cease being fully children. The state of childhood marks that within human being that is non- or pre-human.

Similarly, adultism is able to associate childhood with the sub-human, that is, forms of non-humanity that appear in the guise of humanity as threats to properly human order. Here, childhood comes to stand for an amorphous fear, something that must be divided off in order to preserve what is good, right, and civilized about human existence. The political theorist Toby Rollo describes a kind of “misopedy” or hatred of children that is animated by a “historical binary opposition between the fully human adult and the sub-human child” (Rollo, 2018: 309). The sub-human child occupies a noumenal space of apparent humanity masking all that threatens humanity with a return to animality. In one way, the sub-human child can come to stand for what dominant groups fear about women, the colonized, and racial minorities, insofar as they are constructed as also childlike. But more broadly, children themselves are positioned as needing to overcome their sub-humanity by ceasing to be children.

This adultist logic of children's non- and sub-humanity can even be found, unfortunately, in critical theory. Nikolas Mattheis (2022) argues, for example, that ecofeminism sometimes makes a damaging association of childhood with non-human nature, as in Donna Harroway's slogan to “Make Kin, Not Babies.” Harroway's argument is that the climate crisis demands a reduced population, which she opposes to the demands of neoliberal natalism. However, such an argument reduces babies and children themselves to “appear only as kin *being made* – whether designed and birthed or nurtured and protected,” thus “assigning child, once again, to an abstracted ‘Nature’” (Mattheis, 2022: pp. 518-19). Harroway's solution is for adults to deny children's being, both literally and figuratively. Mattheis argues that instead it is important to avoid “the (adultist) violence involved in the relegation of children to a separate (nature) sphere” (p. 521) by “‘changing the story’ of kinship in the ‘Anthropocene’” in ways that humanize babies and children. Instead of “Make Kin, Not Babies,” a feminist-childist alliance might assert the need to “Make Kin With Babies” or “Let Children Make (You) Kin” (p. 522). Critiques of sexism and neo-liberalism are undermined if they rest on the backs of the marginalization of children.

In fact, the reduction of children to non-human beings has a long and troubling history. Domination over children is part of a deep historical system of patriarchy, the centering of the adult male “pater” or father as the human standard. Patriarchy is usually associated with issues of gender, but is also, and equally, a marginalization of age. Unlike for women, it has often constructed children as not only lesser but non-human beings: as “blank pages” yet to have humanity written upon them; as “natural animals” lacking human reason; as “pure innocents” removed from human struggle (Wall, 2010: pp. 13-33). These

assumptions remain powerful today. They imagine childhood as in one way or another taking place outside the sphere of human reason, language, and society.

The peculiar ontological problem of adultism is then that childhood is normatively constructed as not only a lesser form of human being but a form of essentially non-human human being. The problem is normative because, while on the surface children are of course understood to be just as human as adults, underlying assumptions about being human suggest precisely the opposite: that childhood stands for the absence of what makes human being distinctively human. Childhood stands for that part of humanity that is sub-human: its nature, biology, irrationality, animality, blankness, or innocence. Adultism constructs childhood as that within humanity that exists to overcome itself. It perpetuates a peculiar and paradoxical binary opposition between human human being and non-human human being.

Adultism and the capacity for knowledge

A second dimension of a fully normative theory of adultism can be found in the area of epistemology, or conceptions of knowledge. The problem here is again associated with assumptions specifically about childhood. In essence, adultism renders children's knowledge not just unknown but unknowable. It makes the very possibility of children providing their own understanding and perspective impossible. It is again a question of marginalization: pushing children's knowledge beyond the written boundaries of the page onto the unwritten edges. Unlike for other groups, however, the issue for children is not just that their capacity for knowledge is discounted. It is that knowledge itself is associated with adulthood. Adultism constructs a binary opposition of adult knowing and child not-knowing, an opposition that renders children's specific knowledges not just secondary but illegible.

The specific situation for children can be seen by taking a careful look at the feminist theorist Miranda Fricker's influential concept of "epistemic injustice" (Fricker, 2007). According to Fricker, marginalized groups like women, racial minorities, and the poor face the epistemological problem of being denied, not only a voice in their societies, but more fundamentally societies' recognition of their "capacity as a knower" (Fricker, 2007: 20). Earlier feminist formulations describe this problem as a "double bind": Women are not only not heard but also not considered capable of having anything worth hearing in the first place (Heywood, 1997; Irigaray, 1993). On Fricker's formulation, epistemic injustice is structural: it renders the misjudgment of women's and other groups' credibility normative. It expresses a generalized social "prejudice" that operates "beneath the radar of our ordinary doxastic self-scrutiny" (Fricker, 2007: 40). Marginalized groups must struggle, not only to express their own specific knowledges, but, unlike dominant groups, to be considered capable of expressing their own specific knowledges to begin with.

While Fricker's concept of epistemic injustice has been usefully taken up in childhood studies (Burroughs and Tollefsen, 2016; Carel and Györfy, 2014; Hanna, 2022), the question remains whether it fully accounts for the problem of knowledge faced by children in particular. After all, Fricker herself refers only to issues of gender, race, and class, and nowhere specifically to issues of age or childhood. This omission is itself

somewhat adultist, since it odd to ignore what is arguably the group most likely across virtually all societies to be considered lacking in capacities as knowers. Phrases like “don’t act like a child” and “don’t be childish” are frequently used to denigrate both adults and children for an incapacity for understanding. If there is a prejudice against any group’s capacity as knowers, this group would seem most obviously to be children.

But Fricker’s blind spot is no accident. The epistemological problem for childhood is peculiarly complex. The concept of adultism suggests that epistemic injustice is rooted, not just in prejudices about capacity, but also in prejudices about knowledge itself. For children, it is not just the *capacity* for knowledge that is assumed to be lacking, but the very *possibility* for knowledge. Adultism associates knowledge with the accumulation of experiences, perspectives, and ideas that gradually form into understandings of the world over time. Knowledge itself, on this view, is inherently temporal, that is, tied up with the amount of time an individual has existed in the world. And so it is inherently non-childlike.

This adultist construction of knowledge can be found throughout history. A particularly influential instance can be found in two related arguments made by the Enlightenment philosopher John Locke. First, ontologically, he claims that human beings are born as “white pages” upon which knowledge and understanding must be written over time (Locke, 1964). And second, epistemologically, he argues that knowledge is “empirical,” meaning that it begins in concrete sensory “experiences” that only develop over time into organized “ideas” and still later into “knowledge” defined as “associations among ideas” (Locke, 1960). These two arguments combine in Locke’s notion (taken from earlier historical figures like Aristotle and Thomas Aquinas) that the “capacity” for knowledge arises in 7-year increments, only reaching fully human fruition at age 21. The result is that children lack “knowledge” in Locke’s sense because they inherently lack time in the world. The possibility to know is a function of age. A child gains the possibility for knowledge, on this adultist logic, only insofar as they cease being a child. And since Lockean empiricism is the foundation of modernity, from science to democracy, the notion that knowledge is necessarily the realm of adults is baked into contemporary life.

This is not the place to enter into the many ways that postmodern philosophy has overcome these kinds of Lockean epistemological oversimplifications. Suffice it to say that both knowledge and the capacity to know have in the past century been shown to involve in a variety of more complex linguistic, symbolic, cultural, relational, structural, power, and other foundations. These newer approaches broadly frame knowledge as based, not simply on empirical development, but on the interaction of differences, diversities, and particularities of “lived experience” (Heidegger, 1962; Husserl, 1982; Ricoeur, 1981). It is even possible to say that knowledge fundamentally arises from the absence of knowledge, or non-knowledge: that is, from lived experiences of “difference” that deconstruct normative assumptions (Kearney, 2003). However, even these post-modern epistemologies are rarely developed with children in mind.

Scholars in childhood studies have started to recognize the need for a distinctive critique of epistemological adultism. As the childhood studies sociologist Hanne Warming argues, the “lens” or “prism” through which sociological knowledge is gained remains fundamentally adult (Warming, 2024). Accessing children’s knowledge is about

more than just observing their agency and listening to their voices. It requires a counter-normative critique of knowledge that she calls “Childhood Prism Research (ChildPRe),” an approach to scholarship that recognizes that “the study of children’s lives offers a privileged lens when it comes to certain issues” (Warming, 2024: 194). In a similar way, the childhood studies theorist Erica Burman argues that adult epistemological privilege needs to be challenged from the perspective of what she calls “child as method”: the analysis of how “childhood can contribute to and enrich wider geopolitical concerns” (Burman, 2024: 2). Childhood is not just another realm of knowledge, but another method for the very production of knowledge. In these and other ways, childhood studies scholars are showing that knowledge itself, whether that of children or that of adults, remains adult-centric without adultist critique.

A telling example can be found in emerging discussions around children’s rights to vote. One of the main (though far from the only) arguments against ageless suffrage is that, while children may have valuable experiences to bring to politics, they lack sufficient knowledge or understanding of their own experiences to vote responsibly; thus, they must rely on adults’ knowledge of children’s lives to be represented politically (Cowley and Denver, 2004). On an adultist view, children are thought not to know what they think about politics, not just because of social prejudice about their capacities, but because political knowledge is itself a natural impossibility. The knowledge required for voting is believed to arise only with time: the time of empirical experience in the world and the time of education into political life. In opposition to this assumption, others argue that the marginalization of children’s knowledge undermines the very foundations of democracy (López-Guerra, 2014). A core tenet of democracy is that those governed by policies and laws should be able to influence their formation, and clearly infants, children, and youth are impacted by democratic choices just as much as adults (Wall, 2021). The last third of humanity to continue to lack basic democratic rights are disempowered in part by the epistemological assumption that they lack political knowledge by nature.

Adultism ultimately complicates and deepens what is meant by epistemological injustice. The problem from the perspective of childhood is not just that children’s otherwise obvious capacities as knowers are obscured by historical prejudice. The problem, rather – or, in addition – is that children’s capacities as knowers are discounted by understandings of knowledge itself. A deeper adultistic analysis is needed of epistemology as such. As briefly suggested here, the capacity to know needs to be reframed in non-temporal terms, not as the organization of experiences into increasing understanding, but as the expression of lived experiences of difference. The basic unit of knowledge is not the normative but the non-normative, that which escapes historically linguistic, cultural, and societal formulation. In whatever way epistemology is rethought, its adultist critique would benefit not only children but also adults. Since children too are full human beings, any insight into children’s ways of knowing is also insight into human ways of knowing. As long as “knowing” and “non-knowing” are defined in terms of “adulthood” and “childhood,” the effort to know as such is distorted and impoverished.

Adulthood and political disempowerment

A third dimension of normative adulthood can be found, finally, in the area of politics, broadly understood as any exercise of power. If childhood is associated with non-human being and non-knowledge, then it is hardly surprising that it is also associated with the lack of rights to exercise power. Adulthood in this political sense is not just the assumption that only adults deserve the right to power. In a more profoundly normative sense, adulthood establishes a binary opposition of adult empowerment and child disempowerment. Adults have the right to power precisely because children do not. Adults themselves can be disempowered by being constructed as child-like: as has been the case for colonized peoples, women, racial and ethnic minorities, the disabled, and many other groups throughout history. And sometimes children can be empowered by being considered adult-like: as in the case of climate protesters, gun opponents, Black juvenile offenders, and child labor activists. But the logic remains the same: Adulthood empowers any group constructed as adults through the specific disempowerment of any group constructed as children.

This binary logic of power has long been noted in relation to other marginalized groups. Marx (2000) long ago pointed out that economic power is structured, not just by accumulations of wealth, but by a class dynamic that robs the proletariat of the ownership of its own production. The philosopher Foucault (1977) argues that social, political, and sexual power is not just an exterior force but an internalized structure by which individuals and social groups are historically differentiated. The sociologist Bourdieu (1984) shows that class power is enforced by distinctions of aesthetic taste. Feminist legal scholar MacKinnon (1989) demonstrates that political and legal power are structured around not just the historical power of men but a gendered binary opposition between male domination and female subordination. Other feminist and queer scholars like Butler (1993) claim that political power is bifurcated by ritualized gender performances. In these and other ways, it has been well established that power is exercised over marginalized groups by instituting a wide range of intersecting binary norms.

While such analyses are directly applicable to power relations *between* children – say, between privileged and underprivileged children, boys and girls, and Black and White children – it is not necessarily the case that they entirely capture the power dynamics that take place between children and adults. Adulthood may present its own distinct kind of problem, just as sexism, racism, and coloniality operate somewhat differently from each other as well. If so, then the analysis of power remains incomplete without an intersectional analysis of adulthood.

What adulthood adds to this conversation is a critique of how power operates interdependently. Adulthood constructs a false binary opposition between an independent and therefore empowered adulthood and a dependent and therefore justifiably disempowered childhood (Wall, 2019b). Adults have the right to power because children need power exercised upon them. Adulthood is coded as socially, politically, economically, culturally, and in general “independent” while childhood is coded as contrastingly in all these ways “dependent” on the actions of others. When a group or individual is constructed as independent, they gain the right and responsibility to exercise power over others. When a

group or individual is understood instead as dependent, it is not only the right but also the responsibility of independent groups to exercise power over them for their own good. Any childlike association for any group – whether children, women, minorities, the disabled, the elderly, or the colonized – suggests a lack of independence and therefore a lack of right to power. The construction of independent adulthood versus dependent childhood justifies the empowerment of some at the expense of the disempowerment of others.

Consider the example of international law around discrimination. The legal scholar Aoife Daly shows that international discrimination law rarely identifies children (as opposed to racial minorities, women, the disabled, and various other groups) as belonging to a discriminatory class (Daly et al., 2022). This omission is maintained despite the fact that international law defines discrimination very broadly as “differential treatment in comparable situations without an objective and reasonable justification” (Vandenhoe, 2005: 83). It ought to be the case, legally speaking, that any differential treatment of children must be explicitly and deliberately justified on “objective and reasonable” grounds. In fact, however, any such need for justification is largely assumed to be unnecessary. Indeed, there is no international treaty against children’s discrimination. The landmark discrimination treaties concern race and gender: the International Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Racial Discrimination, and the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women. Even the Convention on the Rights of the Child only prohibits, in Article 2, discrimination on the grounds of race, ethnicity, sex, language religion, disability, and other factors, but not – unless included under “other status” – on the grounds of being a child.

The reason that children are marginalized from international discrimination law is that such law contains hidden adultist biases. If discrimination means, as above, “differential treatment in comparable situations,” it remains possible to interpret children’s situations as non-comparable and hence not protected. Children’s economic and other types of dependence on adults can suggest that their particular “differential treatment” is naturally justified. These languages of legal discrimination place children in a double bind. They must first prove their equal power to act on their own behalf before they can claim that this right is being discriminated against.

For discrimination law to account for adultism, it would need to conceptualize power differently. Discrimination would need to be understood as the denial of not an independent but an inter-dependent access to power. It would need to be reframed as a denial of empowerment as an interdependent part of society. Discrimination law would then attack the problem of any kind of bias: whether undermining persons’ independent capacities to act or failing to respond to persons’ dependence on others for inclusion. The adult-child binary currently distorting discrimination law would be overcome by recognizing that discrimination occurs across the full spectrum of human relations regardless of relative dependency on others. The problem, in other words, is not *differential* treatment but *disempowering* treatment. Everyone’s situation is different, but no one deserves to hold less power over their society than anyone else.

A different example of adultist disempowerment can be found in the arena of academic scholarship. Just as researchers can unwittingly import larger social norms that are sexist, racist, or colonialist, so also can they import into their work a hidden and distorting

adultism. Education philosopher Tanu Biswas and colleagues have developed for this purpose what they call “The Adultcentrism Scale”: “a research tool in the form a questionnaire developed to measure and analyze adultcentric bias” (Biswas et al., 2024: 6). Both researchers and their subjects make use of unconscious or normative biases that may favor adult over child power. These biases range on a scale from children being viewed as “empty boxes” merely to be filled by adults, to being “without agency” and so requiring adults to act on their behalf, to not being “competent” and so needing adult socialization and guidance (p. 6). Such a scale makes it possible to differentiate degrees to which researchers and their subjects harbor normative biases about the justifiability of disempowering children simply because they are children.

Finally, one could point to the adultism involved in political logics of developmentalism. If children are constructed as “developing” beings and adults as “developed,” then the former can rightly be ruled over by the latter. As the political philosopher Toby Rollo points out, “politics remain[s] so hostile to the substantive inclusion of children ... [because of] the developmentalist conception of politics itself,” the notion that politics is always in a state of development toward a fully rational and responsible ideal (2024: 31). On an adultist logic, adults can rightly disempower children because children are only future, not present, political beings. Children themselves must be subordinated to adult power so that democracy can continue to advance. Sana Nakata and Daniel Bray locate this politics of adultism in colonial modernity: “we can understand the infantilization of Indigenous peoples as a logic that arises in the very formation of modernity itself” (Nakata and Bray 2023: 308). In this case, one could argue, colonialism rests on adultism more than the other way around. The colonized group needs to be associated with childhood in order to be disempowered for its own supposed good.

All people and groups deserve equal social empowerment. They deserve that their own particular lived experiences of difference have the same impact as those of others on their shared social environments. The critique of adultism shows that this problem of power tends to be understood in oversimplistic terms as a problem of the denial of agency, freedom, or independence. The more complex reality, for children and adults both, is that political marginalization rests on empowering some by disempowering others. Adultism constructs supposedly independent and rational groups as rightfully exercising power on their own terms. And it correspondingly constructs supposedly dependent and irrational groups as needing power exercised upon them. Adultism proclaims the false logic that empowerment justifies disempowerment. Adulthood needs to be powerful because childhood needs to be ruled over. The deeper reality, however, is that empowerment is interdependent and rightly shared by all.

Conclusion

The concept of adultism still remains outside the mainstream of scholarly and societal discourse. But it should be just as important a critical lens as sexism, racism, colonialism, and other much more widely understood concepts. As in these other cases, adultism is not just about one group or occasional situations of domination or mistreatment. Rather, it describes deep-seated structural norms that distort all aspects of life. Understood

normatively, adultism is a pervasive and historically rooted sets of assumptions that impact everything from self-perceptions to social relations, cultural assumptions to political systems, and educational aims to academic research. It is necessarily intersectional with other normative biases. And like any critical perspective, it can be understood and theorized in different and even conflicting ways. But the important point that fails to be appreciated in both the academy and societies is that adultism is a needed critical lens not just on children but on the whole range of human relations.

As I have defined it here, adultism is the normative empowerment of adulthood through its binary opposition to childhood. It rests on the assumption that adulthood defines what it means to be human, to have knowledge, and to exercise power. Because of this, adultism cuts across other normative biases such as sexism, colonialism, and disablism to justify any group's disempowerment by its supposed childlikeness. Adultism is radical and profound because it constructs childhood as not only a lesser form of human being but a form of essentially and paradoxically non-human human being; it associates childhood with not only the incapacity but the impossibility for knowing; and it structures power as the rule of a supposedly independent adulthood over a supposedly dependent childhood. Adultism thereby functions as a complex and largely unseen normative system demanding the disempowerment of children as children.

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